



GM cutting costs

GM drops wireless smartphone charging support from some of its SUVs due to the chip shortage. <https://digit.in/aug21-35>



Twitter shutting down offices

Twitter closes New York and San Francisco offices in response to new CDC guidelines. <https://digit.in/aug21-36>

while the army engineers became geologists and astronomers. The local journals focused on “oriental studies” allowed these amateur scientists to publish their research in English.

In 1876, Mahendralal Sarkar, a Bengali doctor, founded the Indian Association for Cultivation of Science (IACS), with a laboratory dedicated to the general public, along with lectures and demonstrations by notable Indian scientists. These lectures were in physics, chemistry, maths, geology and botany, all subjects considered unimportant by the British in India.

In 1902, the Board of Scientific Advise (BSA) was formed to provide guidance to the administration, but the Government of India at that time wanted basic research to be left to scientists back in Britain. This body was important for the war effort during World War I, and was rechristened as the Council of Scientific & Industrial Research (CISR), a name that it retains to this day. The Indian Science Congress (ISC) held its first meeting in 1914, and was formed by two British chemistry professors, JL Simonsen and PS MacMahon, with a view of holding conferences between researchers working in the field, on similar lines to the British Association for the Advancement of Science. The ISC was the primary body for providing scientific advice to the government, protect the interests of the scientific community in India, and advance science in India. It remained so till around 1930, when a number of competing organisations cropped up, with similar objectives. We will circle back to this in a bit. In 1917, JC Bose set up the Bose Institute for interdisciplinary research, supported by Swami Vivekanand, Sister Nivedita and Rabindranath Tagore. It quickly attracted a large and diverse crowd of both local and visiting European scholars.

In the 1890s the industrialist Jamshedji Tata wanted to use his wealth for setting up a research institution in India where the local youth could study fundamental sciences, and

approached the Viceroy of India for the same. A committee formed by the Royal Society of London recommended that such an institution be formed, leading to the establishment of the Indian Institute of Science (IISc) in Bengaluru in 1909, on land donated by Krishnaraja Wadiyar of the Mysore state. Chemistry and electrical technology were the first two academic divisions of the institute. During World War II, the research divisions expanded to metallurgy, mechanical engineering and aeronautical engineering. In 1904, Amritlal Sarkar took over administration of the IACS from his father, and welcomed a finance officer at the British Government who liked to work at the



Mahendralal Sarkar, founder of the first modern scientific research institution in Asia

institute in the evenings. This officer was CV Raman, who would go on to win the Nobel Prize in 1930 and become the first Indian director of the IISc in 1933.

The problem really started in the 1930s, when regionalism and politics showed their ugly face, and there was a power struggle between scientific organisations in anticipation of the impending freedom from being under the thumb of the British. When the then Congress President Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose proposed to start the National Planning Committee (NPC) with M Visvesvaraya, a

prominent Indian Civil Engineer at the helm, the astrophysicist Meghnad Saha suggested Jawaharlal Nehru for the post instead, reasoning that the recommendations of the committee would not be taken seriously if it were not led by a prominent politician. The NPC came out with a 27 volume report outlining a comprehensive plan for the development of Independent India, but these reports were buried by Gandhi and never saw the light of day. However, the United Provinces Academy of Sciences was established in Allahabad. In the 1930s, the Government of India wrote to universities, societies and institutions for the formation of a National Research Council that would cooperate with the International Research Council. Raman was unhappy with the representation of south Indian scientists on the drafting committee, and moved ahead to form the National Institute of Sciences, while Saha and others went on to form the National Academy of Science in Calcutta, which later moved to Delhi. While we tend to glorify the feats of the scientists of this period including CV Raman, MN Saha, JC Bose, M Visvesvaraya and Ramanujam, we fail to see them as flawed people who made some decisions that sabotaged institutions in the country. Because of the politics of both Raman and Saha, and a failure of talks, there was a schism in the Indian scientific community. At the time of Independence, C Rajagopalachari attempted to unify the three science bodies, the United Provinces Academy of Sciences in Allahabad, the Indian Academy of Science in Bengaluru and the National academy of Science. However the discussions failed to arrive at a resolution, with Raman objecting to Leigh Fermor as the first president, even though it was common practice for European scientists to helm local institutions, and even though Raman's own institute had a number of western fellows. The failure of these talks was the seed of regionalism that was planted firmly and took a toll on the entire scientific community. **d**